

support to its coalition with Samajwadi Party (SP) led by Mulayam Singh Yadav, SP supporters had allegedly attacked the state guest house in Lucknow, kidnapped BSP MLAs and had tried to assault Mayawati. Ahmed, a close ally of Yadav, had led the attackers from the front but Mayawati was saved due to the intervention of senior BJP leaders after which the two parties had formed the government in the state.

It is believed that the fresh offensive mounted by the chief minister is rooted in her deep sense of insecurity.

leader Brahmdutt Diwedi, who had fought against Ahmed and his men during the attack on the state guest house. A grateful Mayawati had obliged the Diwedi family by not contesting against Diwedi's widow in a by-election. Another of her opponents is independent MLA, Raghuraj Pratap Singh alias Raja Bhaiyya, against whom and against whose father Mayawati had slapped POTA during her earlier stint in power, allegedly for conspiring to assassinate her. The BSP leadership feels that Raja Bhaiyya,

which has a population of 18.6 crore and a police strength of 1.72 lakh, second only to Maharashtra, there is one policeman for a thousand citizens. The number of persons who were provided police protection for more than six months in 2005 was 1,506—highest in the country—and more than 3,000 personnel were deployed for them. The ruling parties have consistently ignored repeated court directives to withdraw police security from individual duties. In Yadav's regime, even student leaders were provided police



HAVE GUN, FEEL SAFE: Mulayam is one of the most heavily protected

She believes she is a prime target of some of her political opponents and therefore has gone to the extent of saying, "If I am killed, the UPA Government led by the Congress would be responsible." The Congress is unable to defend itself as it is an open secret that some of its leaders are allegedly sheltering Ahmed in Delhi. In the recent Assembly elections, the Congress picked up Vijay Singh, another mafia don facing more than three dozen criminal cases and fielded him as its official candidate against BSP. Singh had earlier been sacked from BSP and was convicted for the murder of senior BJP

wanted by the state police in a recently-lodged criminal case, too is being sheltered by the Congress.

The state police was shaken when STF nabbed two hardcore terrorists in December who allegedly confessed to hatching a conspiracy to kidnap Gandhi family scion Rahul Gandhi during his visit to Lucknow. Sources say the same terrorists had been detained earlier and had revealed the same information, but had been let off after interrogation.

VIP security has always been a headache for the state police, whose burden is growing by the day. In a state

protection. Officially, there are state and district level teams that decide the threat perception but in reality ruling party leaders take the final call. In the current regime, ministers, MLAs and petty political workers, some of who face criminal cases, have been given police security.

The increased focus on select individuals has left a large section of the public vulnerable to terrorist strikes as security arrangements remain grossly inadequate at public places. Attacks in the recent past may also have gone up because neither the police nor the top administration has the time to think about the common people's needs. ■

MOST VULNERABLE

VVIPs and VIPs living with maximum threat, and security

Z Includes: 1 bullet-proof car, 2 escort vehicles, 2 personal security officers, security at home & office, state police

SPECIAL MAYAWATI, MULAYAM SINGH YADAV, KALYAN SINGH, T.V. RAJESHWAR & 5 OTHERS

Z Includes: Same as Z Special but with only one escort vehicle instead of two
CATEGORY BENI PRASAD VERMA, SRI PRAKASH JAISWAL, OM PRAKASH SINGH, PRAMOD TEWARI & 4 OTHERS

Y Includes: 2 personal security officers, security at office and home
CATEGORY DADDU PRASAD, INDRAJEET SAROJ, MANOJ KUMAR PANDEY, DINESH PRATAP SINGH & 19 OTHERS

X Includes: 1 personal security officer, security at office and home
CATEGORY KESHARINATH TRIPATHI, YOGI ADITYANATH, HASHIM ANSARI, RATNA SINGH & 12 OTHERS